



Soil is Alive!

By Anna Kirschberg



Book Summary

This non-fiction book looks at the science of soil, with vibrant, diverse and modern photography. Features of the Book – Phase 5 Vowel Sounds; a-e, e-e, i-e. The text will introduce the reader to new and more complex vowel sounds.

This book follows the Beanstalk Books (Letters & Sounds) Phase 5 progression and focuses on teaching new vowel sounds and alternative pronunciations.

Skills and Strategies

This book builds on decodable reading strategies for high/low readers. The book has been written using a strictly controlled vocabulary. Text uses only **decodable regular words** (according to the week by week progression of Letters & Sounds) along with 'Heart Words' or 'Common Exception Words' (CEWs). Heart Words are frequently used words that are not decodable at this phase.

Phase 5 - Vowel Sounds

ay	ou	ie	ea	oy	ir	ue	aw
wh	ph	ew	oe	au	ey	a-e	e-e
i-e	o-e	u-e					

Heart Words:

is, of, the, as, go, to, there, they, are, by, we, one, some, what, have, include, role, moles, could, would, kind, these, ease, through, humans, water, their, ecosystem, live, earthworm

This book also supports other key reading strategies:

- Recognising the relationship between words and images;
- Pointing one-to-one at each word to ensure an appropriate match;
- Vocabulary and word study.

This book also supports key comprehension strategies:

- Making connections between prior knowledge and the text;
- Summarising the main ideas.

This book also supports non-fiction strategies:

- Gaining information from photographs;
- Encountering curriculum related terms and concepts.

Introducing the Text

Open up the discussion about the front cover image and make connections with the children's prior knowledge of this topic. Prompt discussions by using the vocabulary in the book.

What does the title of the book tell you about the front cover image?

What do you already know about this topic?

Read the title and the name of the author to the group. Read aloud the featured heart words from each phase, from the front inner cover.

Reading the Text

Pages 2 and 3 – Explain where to begin reading, and ask the student to point to each word as you read aloud together. Sound out the individual letter sounds as you go, for example: 'alive' = /a//i//v//e/, where the word ends with a magic-e vowel sound.

Pages 4 and 5 – In these photographs, describe what you can see in the images and review the text together. Identify the words in the text that feature the focus alternative vowel sound groups.

Pages 6 and 7 – Here, the reader will encounter words like 'made' that feature vowel sound 'a-e'. Can they think of any other words that contain 'a-e'? Based on their phonics knowledge, can they decode these words as they read them?

Page 8 – Describe what the photograph on the final page is showing.

Children can now read the book independently. At the end of the book, go over the text and photographs again and discuss what is happening on each page.

Revisiting the Text

As a group, refer back to the table in the front inner cover and identify the words in the story that use the new vowel sounds being taught in Phase 5. Identify as many new vowel sounds as you can in words in the text.

Look at the use of punctuation in the story. Can you find the pages with a question mark in the text? Are there any new 'heart words' featured?

Following Up

Use the BLM for this story, the students can learn more about the different types of vowel sounds being used in the text of the story.